

FREE SAMPLE

Russian Tortoise Care Package

The first 4 pages of the 41-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile & Cost Overview. The contents page shows every one of the 41 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 37 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/russian-tortoise/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free Russian tortoise care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/russian-tortoise/, and stays free.

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What's inside

Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

If you haven't bought a tortoise yet

Read pages 4 through 13 in order before buying anything; the enclosure and the UVB fixture are the decisions people get wrong most. Then shop from the Budget and Shopping List on page 29. Read page 25 too: the four-inch rule shapes what you can legally buy and from whom, and almost everyone repeats it wrongly.

If your tortoise is already set up

Audit against the Setup Checklist on page 27. Two things are worth checking today whatever else you do: the actual surface temperature of the basking spot with an infrared thermometer, and the age of the UVB bulb, because output falls away months before the light looks dim. Between them they cause most shell deformity and respiratory infection.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|---|
| ☐ Page 27: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 34: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 28: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 35: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 31: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 36: Equipment, Supplement & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 32: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 13: the never-feed list, for the fridge |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Russian tortoise advice is unusually contradictory, because the animal is genuinely hardy and so a lot of substandard care produces a tortoise that survives for years while slowly deforming. The commonest failures, a glass tank, weak UVB, damp bedding, and too much food, all take years to show. Every figure here is cross-checked against veterinary and specialist tortoise sources, listed on page 39, and every temperature and dimension is given in both imperial and metric.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A reptile veterinarian with tortoise experience. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything health-related is a professional call, not a page in this book. Find that vet before you need one, and write the number on page 28. A general small-animal clinic often cannot help with a tortoise, and this species lives long enough that you will need one eventually.

SECTION 01

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Testudo horsfieldii</i> . Also sold as the Horsfield's tortoise, steppe tortoise, or four-toed tortoise
Native range	Central Asia: Kazakhstan, Uzbekistan, Iran, Afghanistan, Pakistan and western China
Habitat	Semi-arid steppe, rocky desert and dry scrub. A burrowing animal, not a rainforest one
Adult size	5 to 10 inches (13 to 25 centimeters) is the range usually quoted, though the largest verified is about 22 cm (8.7 in) straight carapace length (SCL). Females are usually larger than males
Captive lifespan	40 years or more, with individuals reaching 50 plus. Plan for succession of care, not just your own ownership
Diet type	Herbivore. High fiber, low protein, low sugar, high calcium. Page 11
Indoor enclosure	4 by 2 feet (120×60 cm) is the floor; 7×3.5 ft (210×105 cm), about 24.5 square feet, is the target. Page 5
Enclosure type	Open-topped tortoise table, not a glass tank. This is a ventilation and behavior issue, not a preference
Basking surface	95 to 100°F (35 to 38°C), measured on the surface with an infrared gun
Cool end	70s°F (about 21 to 26°C). Tolerates night lows to 60°F (16°C) without supplemental heat
UVB	Linear T5 HO tube (T5: a fluorescent tube five-eighths of an inch across; HO: high output), target ultraviolet index (UVI) 3.0 to 4.0 at the basking site. Page 7
Humidity	Low ambient, about 30 to 50%, with a moist hide. Page 8
Brumation	Physiologically programmed, 10 to 14 weeks at most, and optional indoors. Page 23
Social	House alone, or with care two females. Never two males. Page 10
Legal status	Colorado bans it; five states require a permit. Page 25. Vulnerable on the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) Red List, and listed under CITES, the Convention on International Trade in Endangered Species

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$372 to \$775 for a full indoor setup, of which \$125 to \$250 is the table alone. The tortoise itself is \$50 to \$400 depending on age and origin. Page 29.

Ongoing

\$365 to \$715 a year: food, supplements, substrate, UVB replacement, an annual vet check, and electricity, which rises in winter in a cold climate.

THE NUMBER THAT SHOULD DECIDE THIS

Forty years. A tortoise bought for a ten-year-old is likely to outlive that child's own children's interest in it. Rehoming a Russian tortoise is genuinely common and genuinely difficult, so the honest question before buying is not whether you can care for one now but who takes it in 2050. Write that person's name on page 28.